

The Andes



THE ANDES are the longest chain of mountains in the world. They stretch right down the western side of South America, from the Caribbean Sea in the north to Cape Horn in the south. Below the peaks of the Andes lie high plateaus, studded with lakes. To the east, the land slopes down toward the grasslands of the pampas and the rainforests of the Amazon basin.

Animals that live in the mountains have to cope with the thin air at high altitudes. Some have developed extra-large hearts and lungs to help them get enough oxygen. The temperature in the high Andes drops to around 14°F (−10°C) at night, so animals such as the vicuna have thick coats to keep them warm.

Whistling guard

Most vicunas live in a small family group, which is fiercely guarded by an adult male. If the male spots any sign of danger, he whistles loudly to give the alarm so that the females and young can escape. Vicunas can run at speeds of up to 29 mph (47 kph) over long distances.



Vicuna
(*Vicugna vicugna*)
Height at shoulder: up to 2 ft 11 in (90 cm)
Body length: up to 6 ft 3 in (1.9 m)

Digging bird

The dark-faced ground tyrant digs a long underground burrow with a nesting chamber at the end. The bird uses its beak as a pickaxe and clears away soil with its sharp claws. The ground tyrant runs quickly along the mountain slopes on its long legs, snatching insects from the ground.



Dark-faced ground tyrant
(*Muscisaxicola macloviana*)
Length: up to 6.5 in (16.5 cm)

Darwin's frog
(*Rhinoderma darwini*)
Length: up to 0.1 in (0.3 cm)



Wide wings

The Andean condor is one of the largest flying birds that has ever lived. It has huge wings and can soar and glide for long distances. The condor eats the flesh of dead animals. Its head and neck are bald, so it can reach into a carcass without dirtying any feathers.



Andean condor
(*Vultur gryphus*)
Wingspan: up to 10 ft 6 in (3.2 m)



Southern pudu
(*Pudu pudu*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 7 in (80 cm)

Smallest deer

At only 15 in (40 cm) tall, the southern pudu is the smallest deer on the American continent. It lives in remote areas of the mountain lowlands and is very shy. This makes it hard to observe, and very little is known about its behavior. It is mostly solitary and feeds on leaves, shoots, and fruit.

Frogs in the throat

The male Darwin's frog carries his tadpoles in pouches in his throat to keep them safe from enemies. While the tadpoles are in his throat, the frog can make only a faint call. After 50 to 70 days, the tadpoles change into tiny froglets and the male spits them out. The female plays no part in rearing the young.

Handy nose

The mountain tapir lives in the mountain forests. Its snout and upper lip are joined together to form a short trunk, which it uses as a nose and as an extra hand to tear leaves from branches. Tapirs are hunted by many animals, including the jaguar, and must always be on the lookout for danger.



Mountain tapir
(*Tapirus pinchaque*)
Body length: up to 6 ft 6 in (2 m)